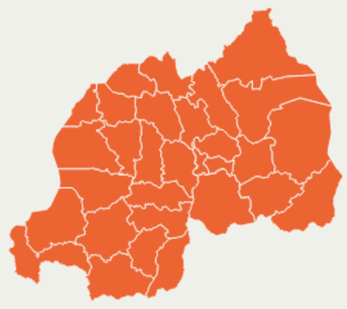
FROM 196 TO 36: RWANDA SAVED ITS CHILDREN. NOW IT MUST HELP THEM GROW.

Seven national surveys, 1992 to 2025, on the first five years of life: who survives, who grows, and where the next gains must come from.



30 DISTRICTS · 7,293 CHILDREN MEASURED

UNDER-5 DEATHS PER 1,000 BIRTHS

36

Down from 196 in the 2000 survey.
Table 8.1, Figure 8.1.

CHILDREN UNDER 5 STUNTED

26.8%

About 1 in 4. 95% CI 25.4–28.1%.
Table 11.1.

NST2 TARGET, 2029

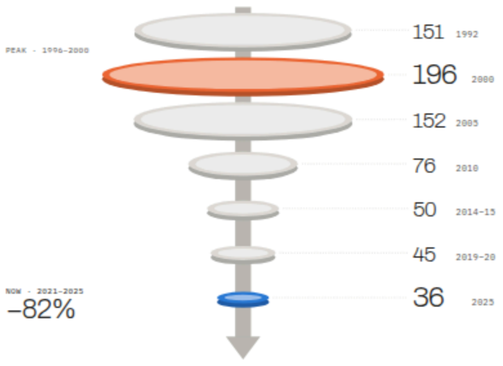
15%

At today's pace Rwanda reaches about 23% (authors' estimate).

01 · SURVIVAL WE KEPT THEM ALIVE

In 2000, about 196 of every 1,000 babies died before their fifth birthday. Today it is 36: 160 more children in every 1,000 grow past age five.

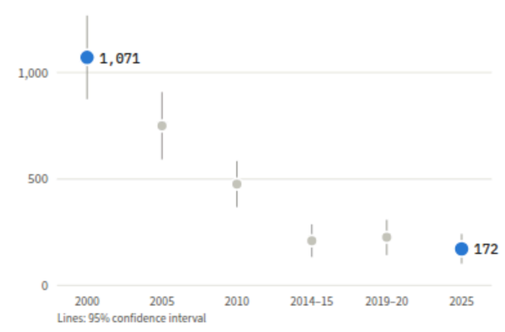
UNDER-5 DEATHS PER 1,000 LIVE BIRTHS, 5 YEARS BEFORE EACH SURVEY



Source: NISR, RDHS 2025 Final Report, Figure 8.1 p.138

Mothers too: pregnancy-related deaths –84%

Per 100,000 live births



Source: NISR, RDHS 2025 Final Report, Table C.18 p.442

02 · CARE CARE REACHED EVERY MOTHER

Births moved into health facilities, antenatal visits multiplied, and families gained control over when to have children.

1 **Births in a health facility**
25% 1992 → 98%

2 **Mothers with 4+ antenatal visits**
12% 1992 → 78%

3 **Married women using modern contraception**
12.9% 1992 → 64.2%



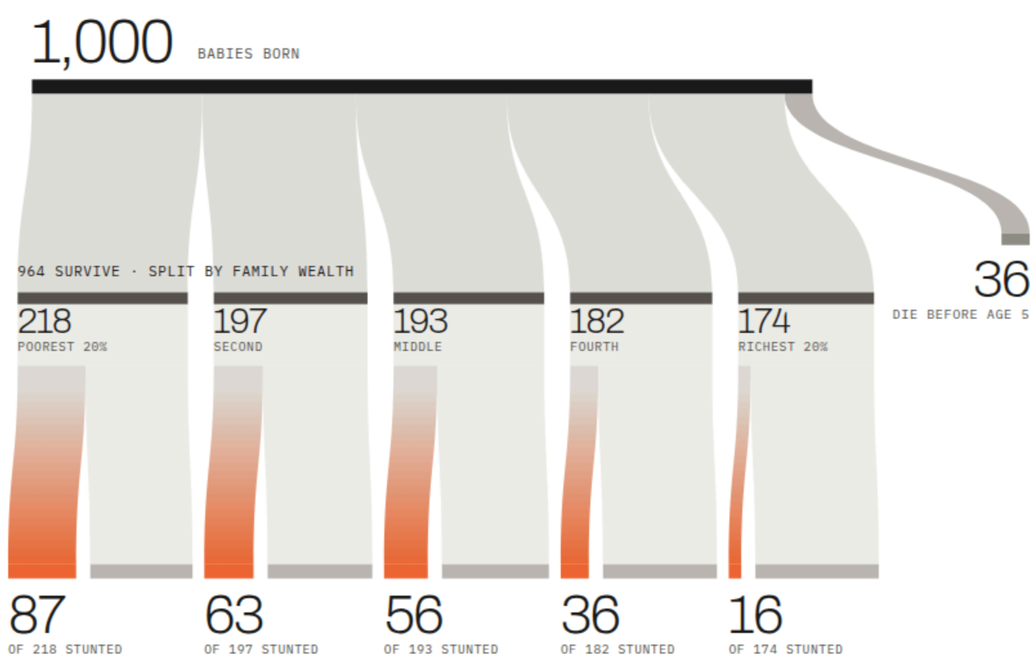
4 **Children with all basic vaccines**
76% 2000 → 94%

Source: NISR, RDHS 2025 Final Report, Figure 10.2 p.184; Figure 9.1 p.146; Figure 9.2 p.149; Table 7.4.1 p.121 (95% CI: Table B.2)

03 · THE COHORT FOLLOW 1,000 BABIES BORN TODAY

Almost all now survive. But one in four survivors does not grow as they should, and the poorest families carry most of that weight.

ILLUSTRATIVE COHORT AT 2025 RATES

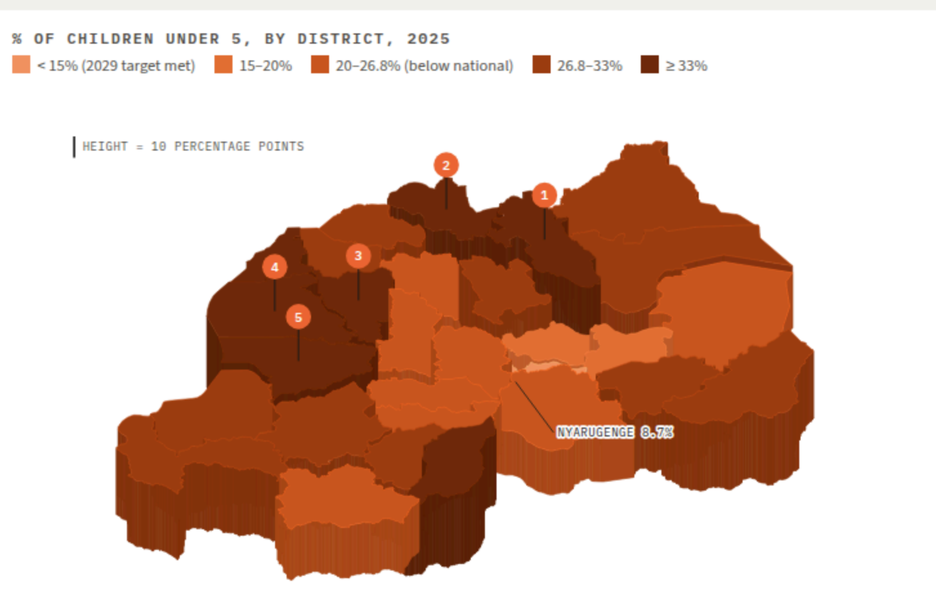


Source: NISR, RDHS 2025 Final Report, Table 11.1 p.220; Table 8.1 p.141

04 · WHERE WHERE CHILDREN ARE STUNTED

Each district is raised by its stunting rate. Kigali sits low; the North and West rise highest. Nyarugenge (8.7%) is the lowest; Gicumbi is 4.5 times higher. Only Nyarugenge and Kicukiro are below the 15% target for 2029.

% OF CHILDREN UNDER 5, BY DISTRICT, 2025

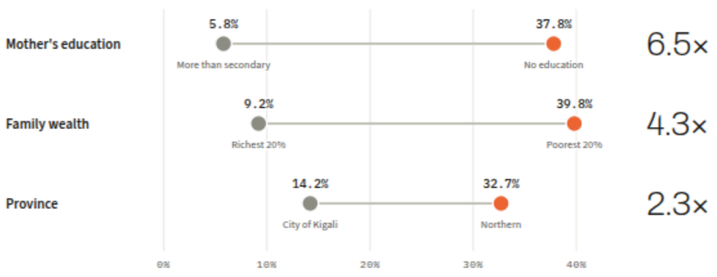


1 Gicumbi · Northern 38.8% 2 Burera · Northern 37.6% 3 Ngororero · Western 35.8%
4 Rutsiro · Western 33.8% 5 Karongi · Western 33.5%

Source: NISR, RDHS 2025 Final Report, Table D.4 p.446

04 · WHO WHO IS LEFT BEHIND

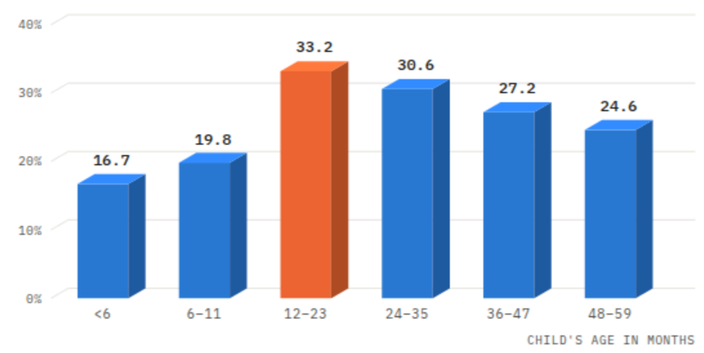
% OF CHILDREN UNDER 5 WHO ARE STUNTED, 2025



Source: NISR, RDHS 2025 Final Report, Table 11.1 p.219; Table 11.1 p.220 (95% CI: Table B.5, B.8)

05 · FIRST 1,000 DAYS THE DAMAGE HAPPENS EARLY

% STUNTED BY CHILD'S AGE IN MONTHS



Source: NISR, RDHS 2025 Final Report, Table 11.1 p.219

05 · FOOD ONLY 3 IN 10 EAT WELL ENOUGH

CHILDREN 6–23 MONTHS WITH A MINIMUM ACCEPTABLE DIET



26.9% GET A MINIMUM ACCEPTABLE DIET

81.8%
exclusively breastfed, 0–5 months

43.5%
eat from 5+ food groups

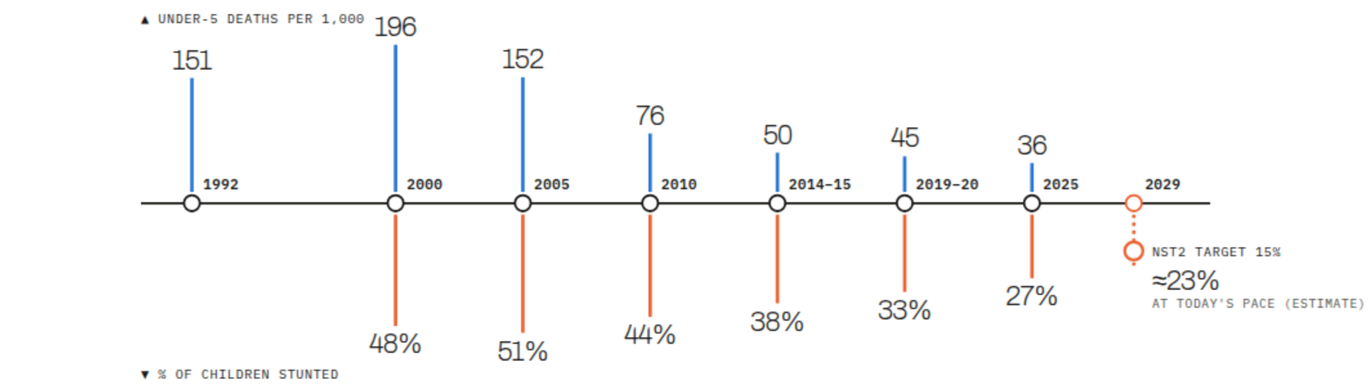
48.4%
eat often enough

Source: NISR, RDHS 2025 Final Report, Table 11.4 p.223; Table 11.8 p.227

06 · TIMELINE FASTER, OR WE MISS 2029

Rwanda's NST2 plan aims for 15% stunting by 2029. At the pace of the last five years, the country reaches about 23%.

UNDER-5 DEATHS PER 1,000 AND % STUNTED AT EACH SURVEY; 2029 = ESTIMATE VS TARGET



Source: NISR, RDHS 2025 Final Report, DHS7 Booklet p.22 (English); Figure 8.1 p.138 (95% CI: Table B.2). Target: NST2 2024–2029 (MINECOFIN). 2029 value is the authors' estimate

FEED VARIETY AFTER 6 MONTHS
Only 27% of children aged 6–23 months get a minimum acceptable diet.

WATCH GROWTH FROM BIRTH TO 2
Stunting doubles between 6 months and 2 years.

KEEP GIRLS IN SCHOOL
Children of mothers with more than secondary schooling are 6.5 times less often stunted.

FOCUS ON THE NORTH AND WEST
Gicumbi, Burera, Ngororero, Rutsiro and Karongi have the highest rates.

Data: NISR, Rwanda Demographic and Health Survey 2025 (RDHS7). Target: NST2 2024–2029. Calculations by the authors.

Team Winners · Moses Mugisha · 2026 NISR Infographic Competition, topic: Rwanda Demographic and Health Survey 2025.

Mortality rates refer to the 5 years before each survey. Stunting: height-for-age below −2 SD of the WHO 2006 Child Growth Standards. The 1,000-baby cohort applies the 2021–2025 under-5 death rate and 2025 stunting rates by wealth quintile; it is illustrative. The 2029 value is the authors' estimate (compound annual rate of reduction, 2019-20 → 2025), not an NISR figure. 3D shapes are isometric: heights are proportional to the printed values. District boundaries: geoBoundaries (CC BY 4.0).